



WEEK ONE · MODULE TWO

Reading the Client Beneath the Request

The confidential note, what is never written down

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This module is not theory. It is the accumulated conduct of people who survived this profession, and of some who did not.

Read it slowly. Nearly every rule here exists because someone learned it the hard way.

Where a script is given, an exact sentence, learn it by heart. You will not have time to compose one in the moment.

CHAPTER I

The economy of trust

Why your name is the only asset you truly own

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Explain why reputation, not skill, is the currency of this profession.

Understand the structure of the market that makes this true.

Apply the two-year rule to your first role.

1.1 · A village of a few thousand people

Private service feels vast from outside and is, in reality, extremely small. A few hundred serious agencies. A few thousand households that employ at this level. Consultants who have known each other for twenty years, and who speak. Principals who discuss their staff at dinner, in front of other principals, with complete frankness and no expectation of consequence.

The practical consequence is absolute, and it governs every decision in this module: **you will change houses four or five times in a working life, and every one of those doors will be opened, or closed, by someone who knew someone.** Your reputation is not a component of your career. It is your career, and everything else, your languages, your competence, your charm, is a decoration upon it.

1.2 · What this changes

- **Never leave a house badly, whatever the provocation.** Serve your notice, hand over impeccably, and say nothing. The satisfaction of the honest exit speech lasts an afternoon; its cost lasts a decade.
- **Never take a role you intend to abandon in three months.** A short tenure with no explanation is the most damaging line on a private CV, and you will be asked about it in every interview for the rest of your life.
- **Never burn a consultant.** Not by applying twice for the same role through two agencies, not by cancelling an interview at short notice, not by accepting a position and then withdrawing. Their reputation is on the table when they present you, and they will not risk it twice.
- **Never speak ill of a former household. Ever.** Not to a friend, not to a colleague, not in an interview when invited to, and not when you are certain you were wronged, which you sometimes will have been.

THE TWO-YEAR RULE

Take the first honourable role you are offered, even if it is beneath your ambition, and be impeccable in it for two years.

Two years is the minimum tenure that reads as stability. It is also, not by coincidence, roughly the time required for a household to trust you completely.

The second role is given by reputation. The third is offered before you have asked. There is no way to skip this, and every attempt to do so is visible to everyone but the person attempting it.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The industry is a village. Everything you do is known.

Reputation is not part of your career; it is your career.

Two years, impeccably served, buys everything that follows.

CHAPTER II

Information hygiene

A doctrine, not a virtue

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Classify every piece of information you hold, and know its permitted channel.

Apply the three questions before speaking.

Operate your devices and your social presence as a professional, not as a private person.

2.1 · Discretion is not silence

Most people believe discretion means keeping secrets. It does not, and that misunderstanding is why so many careful people fail. Anyone can keep a secret; a secret announces itself as one. The craft is in the thousand pieces of information that are *not* secrets, a departure date, a supplier's name, a child's school, a mood at breakfast, the fact that the office called twice, and which, assembled by someone patient, describe a family completely.

DEFINITION

Information hygiene. The disciplined management of the flow of information around a principal: what is recorded, where, in what channel, to whom, and for how long. It is a system, practised identically on quiet days and difficult ones.

2.2 · A classification

Class	Examples, and the rule
Public	What the principal has themselves made public. Even here: you do not comment, you do not confirm, you do not amplify. Silence costs nothing.
Household	Routines, suppliers, staff, standards. Shared within the house on a need-to-know basis, and never outside it. Not even with your family, who will not understand why.
Movement	Where the family is, when, for how long, with whom, and when a residence is empty. This is security information. It travels only through the channels the house has designated, and never in reply to a friendly question.
Personal	Health, relationships, finances, children, conflicts. It does not leave you. It does not enter a message. It is not discussed with colleagues, including those who already know.

Class	Examples, and the rule
Legal / incident	Anything that may become a matter for lawyers, police or press. It goes to the office immediately, in writing, and you make no decisions of your own.

2.3 · The three questions, before you speak

- Does this person need this in order to do their work?
- Would the principal be comfortable hearing me say this, in this room, to this person?
- If this sentence were repeated to a stranger, could it be traced back to the house?

If any answer is uncertain, the sentence does not get said. There is no penalty for having said less.

2.4 · Devices, messages, and the record

- Assume everything you write will one day be read by the principal, by a lawyer, or by a journalist. Write accordingly. This is not paranoia; it is simply true, and it costs nothing to obey.
- Never use a personal messaging application for household business unless the house has instructed it. Use the channel they designate, and only that one.
- Never photograph anything. Not the view, not the aircraft, not the table you laid beautifully. The photograph that ends a career is almost never malicious; it is proud.
- Lock your devices, and enable remote wipe. A lost telephone containing a principal's diary is a security incident, and it must be reported as one, immediately, whatever it costs you in embarrassment.
- Keep your own record, dated, factual, unemotional, of instructions received and decisions taken. Not to defend yourself, but because one day you will need to remember exactly what was said, and memory is not evidence.

2.5 · Social media

This is the fastest career-ending mechanism in the profession, and it claims someone every season.

- No photograph taken inside a residence, a car, an aircraft or a yacht. None. Ever. Not for your mother.
- No location. No "I can't say where I am, but 📍". That is a boast, and a boast is a breach, it announces both that you know something and that you enjoy holding it.
- No public account that permits an employer to be deduced. Consultants will look, and so will the family's security team, and so, occasionally, will a journalist.
- This is not a recommendation. In most serious houses it is a term of employment, and its breach is immediate cause.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Discretion is a system, not a virtue: classify, channel, and say less.

Movement information is security information. Treat it that way always.

Everything you write will be read by someone else. Everything you photograph can end you.

CHAPTER III

Money, gifts, and the quiet corruptions

Almost nobody is dismissed for dishonesty; a great many for ambiguity

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Operate a household budget in a way that is unimpeachable.
- Recognise and refuse the supplier commission, in all its disguises.
- Receive a gift correctly.

3.1 · Why this chapter exists

Trust in a household is destroyed by money more often than by any other single cause, and it is almost never destroyed by theft. It is destroyed by **ambiguity**, a receipt that was not kept, a sum that was advanced and then mentioned, a supplier who is “a friend”, a bonus that was assumed. From outside, ambiguity and dishonesty are indistinguishable, and you will not be given the opportunity to explain the difference.

3.2 · The rules of the household budget

- **Never advance a significant sum from your own funds.** It feels generous and eager, and it is neither: it creates an unclear debt and makes you look either naïve or as though you expect something. Ask for a house card or a float, calmly, and insist gracefully until you have one.
- **Every receipt, every time, without exception.** The one missing receipt is the one that will be remembered, and it will be remembered at exactly the wrong moment.
- **Report before you are asked.** A short monthly summary, unprompted, in the same format each month. A family office will forgive a great deal from someone whose numbers are always tidy and always early.
- **Separate your money from theirs, absolutely.** Never a shared account, never a personal card “just this once”, never a loan in either direction, never holding cash at home.
- **Where there is a threshold for approval, respect it even when it is inconvenient, and especially when the principal has told you not to bother.** Their instruction does not protect you; the office’s record does.

3.3 · The commission, and why it is fatal

A supplier will one day offer you a percentage. It will not be presented as a bribe. It will be a “finder’s fee”, a “trade discount we can share”, a case of wine at Christmas that becomes two, a hotel that upgrades you personally. It is one of the oldest arrangements in this industry and it is entirely normal in some adjacent trades, which is precisely why it is so easy to accept.

Refuse it, and tell the house the same day. Not because you are pious, but because of what it does to you structurally: the moment you take it, you no longer work for the family. You work for the supplier, and every recommendation you make thereafter is compromised, and you will know it, and eventually so will they. In this world it is called a kickback, and there is no recovery from it.

If a supplier offers a genuine trade discount, it belongs to the household, and you say so, in writing, and the household is delighted with you.

3.4 · Gifts

HOW TO RECEIVE

You will be given things: a dress, a watch, a bag, an envelope, a case of wine, a holiday.

Accept graciously. Thank once, briefly, in person if you can. Then never mention it again.

Do not photograph it. Do not wear it in front of them for at least a season. Never speak of its value, and never to another member of staff; the gift that is discussed becomes a grievance in someone else’s hands.

A gift accepted with too much emotion changes the relationship as surely as a gift refused.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Ambiguity about money is indistinguishable from dishonesty. Eliminate ambiguity.

Never advance your own funds. Every receipt. Report early, always.

Refuse the commission and disclose it the same day. It is not a moral question; it is a structural one.

CHAPTER IV

The politics of a household

A sealed system with no appeal

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Position yourself among long-serving staff without threatening them.

Refuse, gracefully, to take a side.

Serve two principals who do not want the same thing.

4.1 · What kind of system this is

A private household is a small, sealed political system with no human resources department, no grievance procedure, and no appeal. Decisions are made on feeling, and they are made quickly. Understand it and you will thrive; ignore it and it will destroy you regardless of how well you do the actual work.

4.2 · The long-serving

The PA of twelve years. The chauffeur of fifteen. The nanny who raised the children. They cannot be beaten, and they should not be beaten. They can only be made into allies, and the method is very simple and slightly humbling: **ask their advice, take it visibly, and credit them in front of the principal.** You will lose nothing. They have no ambition to take your role, they have their own, and it is secure, and in exchange they will tell you things that would otherwise take you three years to learn.

4.3 · Never take a side

- **In a staff conflict there is no winning side.** There is only the side that leaves, and it is usually the newest person, because a family will always protect the old.
- **Never criticise a colleague to the principal,** even when asked directly, especially then. It is a test, whether or not the principal knows they are administering one. “She is finding her feet, and I am helping her” is a complete and adequate answer, and it is also, usually, true.
- **Do not carry grievances upward.** Solve what you can, absorb what you must, escalate only what genuinely endangers the family or the house.

4.4 · Two principals

Where there are two, they will not always want the same thing, and one day you will be standing between them holding a message. Serve both. Favour neither. Never carry a message that has an edge on

it, and never soften one either, you are not a diplomat, and improvised diplomacy between spouses is how staff are dismissed by the one they were trying to protect.

If you are asked, gently, to keep something from the other, decline immediately and warmly, before it becomes a pattern from which there is no exit: *“I’d rather not be in the middle of that, I hope you understand.”* It will cost you a moment of awkwardness. Its alternative costs you the role.

4.5 · The single point of failure

It is tempting to make yourself irreplaceable by holding everything in your own head: the passwords, the contacts, the arrangements, the file only you can read. It feels like security.

It is the opposite. Families do not reward staff who cannot be replaced; they fear them, and fear does not produce promotion, it produces a quiet, deliberate reduction of your access, and eventually a replacement recruited in secret. The professionals who last are those who document everything so completely that they could be replaced tomorrow, and who are, precisely for that reason, never replaced.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The household is a political system without an appeal process.

Make allies of the long-serving by asking, taking and crediting their advice.

Take no side, carry no edged message, keep no secret between two principals.

Document everything. Irreplaceability is a weakness disguised as power.

CHAPTER V

The improper request

The category nobody prepares you for

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Distinguish the impossible from the improper.

Deploy the prepared refusal without moralising, arguing, or improvising.

Escalate correctly, the same day, in writing.

5.1 · The shape it takes

It comes for everyone, usually within the first year, and never in the form you rehearsed. It will be small. It will be reasonable. It will be delivered with a smile by someone charming, and it will be very easy to say yes.

- A journalist who is “only confirming something we already have”.
- A friend of the family, whom you have met at the house a dozen times, who asks warmly how long the house will be empty in August.
- A supplier who would be so grateful for an introduction, and who has been so good to you.
- The assistant of someone important, who needs “just the address, we have it anyway”.
- A member of the family, often not the principal, who asks you to keep something from the other.
- An instruction to alter a date on a document, or to say that you were somewhere you were not. It will be trivial. It will be the beginning.

5.2 · Why the charming version is the dangerous one

Note the technique in the first example: the caller claims to know already, so that confirming feels like nothing. And note the second: familiarity dissolves judgement, which is exactly why a real breach almost always arrives wearing the face of a friend rather than the face of a stranger.

5.3 · The prepared refusal

LEARN THESE BY HEART

To the press: *"I'm not able to help with that."* Then end the call, courteously, and add nothing. Do not confirm. Do not deny, a denial is information. Do not say "I'll have to check", which is a confirmation that you could.

To the charming friend: *"I honestly don't keep track of the family's plans, the office would know."* Warm, unremarkable, and closed.

To the supplier: *"I don't make introductions, I'm afraid, but do send your details to the office."*

To anything that troubles you: *"I'm not able to help with that, but let me pass it to the office."*

You do not argue. You do not moralise. You do not improvise. A line drawn in calm holds; a line you must find in the moment does not.

5.4 · Then escalate

The same day. In writing. One paragraph, factual: who asked, when, what they wanted, what you said. No drama, no accusation, no speculation about their motive.

Two things follow from this, and both are worth the small discomfort. First, if it was innocent, nothing happens and you have lost nothing. Second, if it was not, you are the person who noticed, and being the person who notices is precisely the person a household cannot afford to lose.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The improper request is small, charming, and easy to grant. That is its design.

Have the sentences ready before you need them.

Refuse without argument, escalate the same day, in writing, without drama.

CHAPTER VI

Boundaries, and the cost of this work

The part of the profession that is never advertised

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the confidante trap and the friendship drift.

Protect a life outside the house, deliberately and structurally.

Know what burnout looks like in this profession, and what to do before it arrives.

6.1 · Warmth without intimacy

You will be warm. You will be present at births, illnesses, funerals, arguments, and the ordinary Tuesday evenings of a family's life. And you will not be their friend, and they will not be yours, and the whole art of the profession is holding those two facts at the same time without becoming cold.

Being trusted feels like being chosen. It is not. Trust here is a professional condition. The staff member who becomes a confidante is, in time, quietly moved on, not out of cruelty, but because they have become a witness, and no one wishes to live alongside a witness.

6.2 · The drift, and how to notice it

- You are invited to sit down and stay when the work is finished, and you begin to want to.
- You are told things about the other principal.
- You find yourself defending them to your own friends, with feeling.
- You feel a small, private pleasure at being needed at midnight.
- You stop taking your days off, and you tell yourself it is because they need you.

Each of these is a symptom of the same thing: the role has begun to supply something it was never meant to supply. It ends badly, always, and the ending is not usually theirs, it is yours, in the form of a collapse.

6.3 · Structural protection

- Take your days off, physically away. A day off spent in the house is not a day off; it is a day of quiet duty.
- Keep one relationship, outside this world, that has nothing to do with it, and never tell them anything you should not.

- **Have a professional confidant:** a mentor, a former colleague at another house, a supervisor. Someone with whom you can discuss the *shape* of a problem without ever giving its content. This is what keeps people sane.
- **Money is not a substitute for a life,** and this profession pays well enough that you may not notice you have made that trade until several years have passed.

6.4 · Leaving well

One day you will leave, and how you leave will be worth more than everything you did while you were there. Serve your notice in full. Hand over completely, the file, the black book's relevant contacts, the systems, the calendar, all of it, generously and without withholding. Say nothing to anyone, then or later. Ask, at the end, for a written reference, and ask warmly.

The household you leave impeccably will recommend you for the rest of your working life. That is not sentiment. That is the entire mechanism of this industry, described in one sentence.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Warmth, always. Intimacy, never. Holding both is the art.

Protect your days off, your outside life, and one professional confidant.

Leave impeccably. The exit is the reference, and the reference is the career.

CHAPTER VII

Case law

Five incidents, and what they teach

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the structure of a breach before it becomes one.

Extract the general rule from the particular failure.

The proud photograph

The situation. A guest-relations manager in a chalet photographs a beautifully laid table, at night, empty, with the mountains behind it. No family, no faces, no names. She posts it. Three days later a journalist identifies the chalet from the window, and the family's presence in the valley, which had been kept quiet, is published.

The lesson. She was dismissed, and she was correct in believing that she had done nothing malicious. The lesson is not about malice. **A photograph does not need to contain a person to reveal one.** The window did it. The lesson: no photographs, of anything, from inside the private world. There is no safe version of this.

The friendly supplier

The situation. A house manager accepts, over two years, a series of small kindnesses from a favoured contractor: a case of wine, a weekend, a discount on his own kitchen. He continues to award the contractor work, and the work is genuinely good.

The lesson. A routine audit by the family office notices the pattern. The work being good made no difference whatsoever. **He no longer worked for the family, and everyone could see it but him.** The lesson: refuse, disclose, and route every trade advantage back to the household.

The empty diary

The situation. A PA, asked at a party by an old university friend what her employer is "really like", says almost nothing, but she does say, laughing, that she will finally get a holiday in August because "they'll all be away for three weeks".

The lesson. The friend repeats it, harmlessly, to someone else. The residence is burgled during the second week of August. There is no evidence of any connection, and it does not matter: she is asked to

leave, because the household can no longer be certain. **Movement information is security information**, and it does not become safe because the room is friendly.

The softened problem

The situation. A concierge realises he has missed a visa requirement for a trip four days away. He believes he can resolve it. He says nothing for two days, works desperately, and nearly succeeds. On the third day he tells the office, who cannot now fix it in time.

The lesson. He was not dismissed for the visa. He was dismissed for the two days. **A bad fact delivered early is a manageable fact; the same fact delivered late is a crisis, and the crisis is now about you.** No surprises. Ever. Even when you believe you can save it.

The confidante

The situation. An estate manager becomes, over eighteen months, the person a principal talks to. She is discreet. She never repeats a word. She is also, by the end, the only person in the house who knows the state of the marriage.

The lesson. When the marriage ends, she is let go, with generosity and without explanation. She had done nothing wrong, and that is precisely the point. **She had become a witness**, and the family needed the witness gone. The lesson is not that she should have been colder. It is that she should have understood, from the first evening, what she was becoming, and remained, warmly, exactly what she was hired to be.

Glossary of the module

Information hygiene, The systematic management of what is recorded, said, sent and kept about a principal.

Movement information, Where the family is, when, and when a residence is empty. Always treated as security information.

Kickback, A commission or benefit from a supplier. Fatal, and structurally so.

The improper request, A request that should not be fulfilled, as distinct from one that cannot be.

The confidante trap, The drift from trusted professional to personal confidant, which ends in removal.

No surprises, The standing principle that a bad fact is delivered early, always.

The two-year rule, The minimum tenure that reads as stability, and the time required to be trusted completely.

Self-assessment

Write your answers. Bring the two you found hardest to your mentorship session.

1. Why is reputation, rather than skill, the currency of this profession? Answer in terms of the structure of the market.
2. Classify these into the five information classes: the chef's name; the date of departure for Sardinia; the principal's medication; a public gala photograph; a threatening letter received at the house.
3. A contractor offers you fifteen per cent on everything you send him. Give your answer to him, and your next action.
4. The principal's spouse asks you not to mention a purchase to the principal. What exactly do you say?
5. What are the five signs that you are drifting into the confidante trap?
6. Write, from memory, the four prepared refusals.
7. You have made an error that you believe you can fix quietly in two days. Explain, in one paragraph, why you will not.
8. Why does a household fear an irreplaceable member of staff?
9. You are leaving a house that treated you badly. Describe your exit, in detail, and explain what it buys you.

ÉMILIE'S NOTE

Reserved. This is where I add what I saw, in my own words.

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